Global South Construct: Changing Winds from the Eurocentric perspective of Global Politics

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Mackinder`s heartland theory has become questionable with Europe facing conflicts in various spectrums. Europe which was once the monopolist of international politics in the 19th and 20th century is now losing its grip. It faces a wide range of issues including internal political instability like BREXIT and unsustainable migration politics making political camps within Europe. In contrast, the Global South who were silenced by colonialism and imperialism in the past is now blooming hope. New narratives, alliances, and partnerships are emerging from global south countries making global politics a level playing field. With ideas like IBSA, South-South cooperation, UNSC reform emerging, and the role of India getting prominence the world is now looking south. Innovative solutions for global crises like climate change are emerging from this south bloc. Africa is getting attention and Latin America is no longer an observer in global issues. This paper is an attempt to trace the shift of developments emerging from the global south in international politics which is gaining prominence and challenging the traditional Eurocentric global politics and what impacts these shifts makes to the global goods and global commons.

Key words:

Global South, Eurocentrism, Samir Amin, India, African Union.

Introduction

The term Global-South is an in-exhaustive concept with multiple interpretations of its own kind. Global South is not necessarily a geographical grouping of countries lying below the Equator. India which is leading the Global South narrative is in north of the Equator and Australia which is a AAA rated capitalist economy is in deep South. Global South as a tern traces back its origin to an American political scientist 'Carl Oglesby' in 1969 as a reflex to the dominance and hegemony held by Europe and the West in International Politics. Though the term has leftist tag attached to it no communist nation during cold war or any other period in history tried associating the term Global South as their concept. Antonio Gramsci had a capitalist, socialist interpretation to the North and South countries in his essay the Southern Question. For African decolonization champion Kwhame Nkrumah, he infers Global South as a concept in relevance with decolonization. As most countries in the South including Latin America, Africa, Asia and South East Asia were occupied by Europe are in Southern hemisphere Global South is an anti colonial notion too.

Global South has multiple inferences by different strings attached to it. But one common factors which unites all these different interpretations together is that this idea is a strong resistance to Europe which had a geo political, economic, strategic and policy level dominance it had over the world.

Global South in 21st century has redefined itself with multiple reasons including Europe facing constant internal and external conflicts, Asian powers rising especially India`s economic growth and its voice in global stage is getting attention and Africa coming together stronger than ever before via African Union boldly voicing out their consensus and resisting exploitation. Consolidating all such ideas Global South is a construct that challenges the

powerful Europe and the West and countries steps up to claim their space and role in international politics.

How Global South is different from Europe

The fundamentals of European understanding of international politics emerges from the roots of classical realist principles. Realist scholars especially from the West argues that modern international political system emerged from the Westphalian treaty of 1648. What was the world doing before 1648 is a least matter of concern because nation states and territorial sovereignty became the core of the international politics. Nation state concept is preferred to be the core as its operationally viable and expansion, wars can be justified with such means.

Europe since 17th century, has its core of its political ambition as expansion of power via control to resources. It laid foundation for imperialism and colonization which dominated international politics for almost 3 centuries. The way how Europe looted the Asian, African, Latin America continents cannot be justified in any means. The biggest irony is that countries which takes lectures on territorial sovereignty and respect to statehood often ends up in infringing others sovereignty. Even now Eurocentric scholars believes that international system exist with the patronage of the Europe. The way it tries to justify its dominance despite lacking justifications is losing hold in recent pace of growth from developing countries.

While the bedrock of European politics is colonialism, the Global South emerges with an alternative of mutual cooperation and development. Global South does not necessarily advocates liberal school of international politics, but Global South is pragmatic enough to guide the system in the best rational means. It shares culture, tradition, civilizations, long standing win-win trade which inherently makes a bond between regions. Examples are shared history between India and Southeast Asia, India and Africa and African and Latin America.

Their shared values and bitter colonial experiences enlightens the Global South countries to ensure a level playing field in the international politics, ensuring no exploitation happens in any means. However national interest is preserved by balancing realist strategies and mututal cooperation.

Global South and Frankfurt School of International Relations

Frankfurt school of International Relations is a collective of critical theorist of IR. It emerged as a post positive approach challenging the traditional positive assumptions guiding the discipline and develop a critical theoretical project which would be led by emancipatory interest.

This concepts challenges the realist notion of states which are capitalistic in nature. It argues that states use realism as its tool to justify the illegitimate actions of a state on another state. It also questions the way how realism includes war as tool of national interest and policy decision. It also has a Marxist angle to it advocated by scholars like Andrew Linklater and Richard Ashely who looks international conflicts as class conflicts in a broader spectrum.

Immanuel Wallerstein`s world systems theory can be used here to connect the Global South idea with the Frankfurt school. Nations which are part of the Global South idea are predominantly nations of semi periphery or periphery classified in the world systems theory. The core countries are European countries which has a positivist approach of international politics and follows capitalist economy. While there is a visible conflict observed between core countries and countries in periphery and semi periphery, there is also a similar conflict exist between the Global South countries and European powers between balance of power in international system.

The Global South countries challenges the European dominance in international politics. It is visible in areas like climate change, terrorism where developing bloc blames developing bloc

for not taking necessary policy actions and developing blocs blaming developed blocs for not sharing technology and take the burden in funding sustainable development projects.

The Global South construct is complimentary to the Frankfurt school of International Relations and complimentary to its ideas. Global South when materialized properly can implement the Frankfurt school`s suggestions in the system successfully.

Institutionalization of Global South: Prospects and Challenges

Global South with given theoretical and conceptual backing, and real time relevance it has got in changing the dynamics of international politics. However in order to achieve its goals a strong institutionalized character of Global South becomes eminent. Especially to challenge the European institutions it needs a similar connected network of institution working in close coordination.

Given the multiple interpretations and since it cannot be geographically restricted to a particular area it has got is own limitations in institutionalizing it as regional or sub regional grouping. G-20 cannot be called as Global South institution however it aligns with the ideas of South countries and focuses on developing economies, since it has got European powers it cannot be claimed as a Southern grouping. Though there are regional groupings like the African Union, Caribbean Community, MERCOSUR, UNASUR, SAARC, all these institutions has got a regional purpose and restriction and cannot be institutionalized as a cross continental grouping. One closest grouping to the ideas is the BRICS. The genesis of BRICS comes as group of growing economies challenging the G7 economies has a validity to it. However presence of Russia in its creates a genuine doubt of whether a country in Arctic can be a part of Global South. So there are limitations in BRICS as well.

Despite the institutional hinderances faced by Global South countries it can still come together as a issue based partnerships to work in areas of mutual concern and prospects for

growth. International Solar Alliance is one such example as countries in Southern Hemisphere has maximum potential in harnessing solar power. UNSC reform can also add value to the voice of Global South when India is admitted into the UNSC as a permanent member. There is not even a single representation from the South in UNSC which shows the true characteristic of European nations dominance in global system.

The voice of Global South summit is a game changer in institutionalizing the Southern narrative. The idea was proposed by India and India conducted 3 editions of Voice of Global South summit successfully. In 2024 leaders and representatives from 123 countries joining the summit in virtual mode which shows the growing character of Global South. This is a huge step towards Global South getting an institutional recognition. The Global South together as an entity in coming future will have a greater responsibility in handling new crises that are emerging.

What Global South Means for the 21st Century

During the Rasinia Dialogue of 2024 held in Delhi, the external affairs minister of India Dr S. Jaishankar spoke about the need for re-globalization. While globalization has led to an un equal development within countries and international system as whole it led to emergence of modern issues like terrorism, migration, huma rights crises etc. Over emphasis on the western economies for growth led to weaponization of dependency where the countries are expected to be dependent on the West to protect its interest. It has led to the collapse in balance of power.

The anti dote for the issues created by the globalization and over dependence on West is equitable growth projected by the Global South. The Global South countries focuses on fundamental issues of man kind like human security, food security, energy security, clean drinking water, peace while the West focuses is on great power politics and modern

technologies. The Global South is characterized with equitable growth and cooperation policies by providing a equal space for multiple stakeholder, ensuring a level playing field.

The Global South countries are predominantly developing countries which are still fighting basic issues like poverty. However they are capable to lead the international system with keeping a human centric approach, and universal development goal. Unlike the European colonization mindset the Global South narrative will be for the global good and global common.

Conclusion

The debate between newly developing Global South narrative and existing strong European power center is not who is more powerful or who has access to more resources or who controls the global order. Rather it is about who can solve the contemporary global issues make the world more livable, settle down the existing conflicts, promote mutual cooperation , develop ever lasting peace in battle zones and increase the standard of living of people.

The Global South is the voice of oppressed, the Voice of systematically neglected countries. It is seen as an empowerment of a huge population who were suppressed and exploited for a long period. The Global South concept is gaining prominence in recent times because it has proved it ability to make changes like system. Country like India which was exploited in the past and systematically neglected to express is opinion in world stage is now proudly leading multiple initiatives for global good.

It is making the world order better and stable that ever before. It is solving international issues which were thought to be unsolved. It is bringing in multiple partners around the world despite differences for the betterment of human development. The Global South is a voice of every single individual who is the victim of colonization and imperialism who is now proudly stepping up its standards.

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